

SLAVIC PAGANISM

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Russia, Poland, Ukraine, Czech Republic, Serbia, Bulgaria — Perun, Veles, Baba Yaga, Marzanna, and the Sacred World Before Christianity

Perun throws the lightning.
Veles steals the cattle from heaven
and hides them below the world tree.
Every storm is the same battle
that has always been fought —
the thunder god descending
to reclaim what the underworld god has taken.
Marzanna's effigy is still drowned
every spring
across Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, and Ukraine.
The winter still dies in the river.

I.Q. Productionz

CONTENTS

- Introduction — Slavic Paganism: The Sacred World Before Christianization
- Part One — Who the Slavs Were: The Largest Ethnic Group in Europe
- Part Two — The Slavic Sacred World: Sources and Reconstruction
- Part Three — SLAVIC COSMOLOGY: The World Tree and Three Realms
- Part Four — The World Tree (Mirovoye Drevo): Axis of the Slavic Cosmos
- Part Five — PERUN: The Thunder God — The Supreme Active Deity
- Part Six — Perun's Character: Thunder, Oak, and Sacred Justice
- Part Seven — VELES: God of the Underworld, Cattle, Magic, and the Arts
- Part Eight — The Eternal Conflict: Perun and Veles as Cosmic Principle
- Part Nine — ROD AND ROZHANITSY: The Creator and the Fate Weavers
- Part Ten — THE SLAVIC PANTHEON: All Major Deities in Full Depth
- Part Eleven — Mokosh: The Earth Mother and Sacred Feminine
- Part Twelve — Svarog: The Sky Smith — God of Fire and Crafts
- Part Thirteen — Marzanna / Morana: Goddess of Winter and Death
- Part Fourteen — THE MARZANNA CEREMONY — Step-by-Step (Living Tradition)
- Part Fifteen — Kupala Night (Ivan Kupala) — Step-by-Step
- Part Sixteen — BABA YAGA: The Forest Witch — Complete Sacred Portrait
- Part Seventeen — The Firebird (Zhar-Ptitsa): Sacred Light and Transformation
- Part Eighteen — THE HOUSEHOLD SPIRITS: Domovoi, Dvorovoi, Kikimora
- Part Nineteen — THE DOMOVOI CEREMONY — Step-by-Step
- Part Twenty — Rusalki: The Water Spirits — Sacred and Dangerous
- Part Twenty-One — THE RUSALIA FESTIVAL — Step-by-Step
- Part Twenty-Two — The Volkhvy: Slavic Sacred Specialists and Shamans
- Part Twenty-Three — Sacred Sites: Sacred Groves and the Kapishche
- Part Twenty-Four — Slavic Paganism Under Christianity: Dvoeverie (Double Faith)
- Part Twenty-Five — The Haligricity Lens: The Eternal Conflict as Sacred Teaching

The Sacred World Before Christianization

Slavic paganism — the pre-Christian sacred tradition of the Slavic peoples (Russians, Poles, Ukrainians, Belarusians, Czechs, Slovaks, Serbs, Croats, Bulgarians, and related peoples) — is one of the most significant and most underrepresented sacred traditions in the Western world's understanding of its own spiritual heritage. The Slavic peoples are the largest ethnic group in Europe, and their pre-Christian sacred tradition — which was practiced across an enormous territory from the Elbe River to the Urals — constitutes one of the richest mythological systems on the continent.

The primary challenge in studying Slavic paganism is the near-total destruction of the written record. Christianity arrived among the Slavic peoples from the 9th-12th centuries CE, and the Christianization process was thorough in its destruction of the previous sacred tradition's material expressions. What remains is reconstructed from chronicles written by Christian clerics (who described Slavic paganism in order to condemn it), from archaeological evidence, from the vast body of Slavic folk tradition (the bylina epic songs, the fairy tales, the seasonal ceremonies), and from comparative Indo-European mythology.

THE SLAVIC SACRED WORLD — KEY FEATURES
THE INDO-EUROPEAN CONNECTION: The Slavic sacred tradition belongs to the broader Indo-European religious family — sharing fundamental structures with the Norse, Greek, Hindu, and Celtic traditions. Perun (thunder god) parallels Thor, Zeus, Indra, and the Celtic thunder gods. Veles (underworld) parallels Hades, Yama, and the Norse Hel. The World Tree parallels Yggdrasil and the Hindu cosmic axis. But the Slavic tradition has specific features — particularly the Perun-Veles eternal conflict — that distinguish it from all its Indo-European relatives. THE FOLK TRADITION AS EVIDENCE: The most important evidence for pre-Christian Slavic sacred beliefs is the folk tradition — the seasonal ceremonies, the household spirit practices, the folk tales, and the specific sacred characters (Baba Yaga, the Firebird, the Rusalki) that persisted through centuries of Christianity. These folk elements were not invented after Christianization; they preserve specific features of the pre-Christian sacred world in transformed form. DVOEVERIE (DOUBLE FAITH): The specific way Slavic paganism survived Christianity — not through complete conversion or complete persistence, but through a specific dual system where Christian practices and pagan practices coexisted, often with pagan seasonal ceremonies receiving a Christian saint's name while preserving their pagan content. Marzanna's drowning happens on the Sunday before Palm Sunday. Ivan Kupala Night (Kupala Night) is celebrated on the feast day of Saint John the Baptist. The content is pre-Christian; the calendar date carries the Christian name.

PERUN

The Thunder God — The Supreme Active Deity

Perun (from a Proto-Slavic root meaning 'to strike' — related to the Lithuanian Perkūnas, the Baltic thunder god, and possibly to the Sanskrit Parjanya, the Vedic rain god) is the supreme active deity of the Slavic sacred world — the god of thunder and lightning, of the sky and rain, of war and justice, and the sacred protector of the community against the forces of the underworld.

PERUN — COMPLETE SACRED CHARACTER

PERUN'S DOMAIN: Thunder, lightning, rain, war, sacred oaths, and justice. When Perun throws his lightning bolt, he is not acting randomly — he is enforcing the sacred order against specific violators. Lightning strikes the oak because the oak is Perun's sacred tree, the specific lightning conductor through which his power most directly expresses itself. PERUN'S SACRED ANIMALS AND SYMBOLS: The oak (most sacred tree), the eagle (Perun's bird, riding the highest sky currents), the bull (masculine sacred power), the axe (specifically the stone axe — thunder ax — as Perun's thrown weapon), fire. THE SACRED OAK: Perun's primary sacred site was not a built temple but a specific living oak tree — the sacred grove of oak trees at specific locations (the most sacred being at Kiev, where a statue of Perun stood beneath oak trees with a sacred fire maintained before it). The oak's association with lightning (oaks are struck by lightning more frequently than other trees, and this was understood as Perun favoring his own tree) made it the natural sacred medium of the thunder god. PERUN AS CHIEF DEITY: In the Kievan Rus period — the most extensively documented phase of Slavic paganism — Perun was the primary deity of the prince's and warrior's class. He was invoked in oaths and sacred treaties. The 945 CE treaty between Prince Igor of Rus and the Byzantine Empire specifically invokes both Perun (the Varangian-Slavic god) and Volos/Veles for the oaths of the treaty parties.

VELES

The Eternal Opponent — God of All the Hidden World

Veles (also Volos — from a root related to 'hair,' 'wool,' or 'ox') is the single most philosophically extraordinary figure in the Slavic pantheon — a deity whose domain encompasses the underworld, cattle, wealth, magic, the arts, poetry, and trickery. He is Perun's eternal opponent, and their conflict is the primary cosmic drama of the Slavic sacred world.

VELES — COMPLETE SACRED CHARACTER

VELES'S DOMAIN: The underworld, the dead, the roots of the World Tree, cattle and wild animals, wealth and abundance (associated with the earth's fertility that the underworld's moisture produces), magic, poetry, music, trickery, and the arts. Veles is simultaneously more dangerous and more complex than Perun — he is not evil (the Slavic tradition does not divide into good and evil in the Judeo-Christian sense) but he represents the principle of hidden power, of what is below and within, as opposed to Perun's above and manifest power. **THE ETERNAL CONFLICT:** The Perun-Veles conflict is the defining cosmic drama of Slavic mythology — Veles steals something from Perun's domain (cattle, children, a wife, water), retreats to the underworld or hides in a rock or tree, and Perun pursues him with lightning bolts. Every storm is this pursuit. When lightning strikes a tree, Perun is hunting Veles who has hidden there. When lightning strikes the ground, Perun is attacking Veles below. Rain that follows lightning is the release of the waters that Veles had imprisoned. **THE SACRED BALANCE:** What distinguishes the Slavic understanding from a simple good-versus-evil narrative is that the conflict never ends and neither side permanently wins — the cosmic order requires both Perun and Veles, both the principle above and the principle below, both the storm and the underground moisture that makes the earth fertile. Veles's defeat each time is not his elimination but his retreat to his own domain. The cycle continues because the cycle is the world. **VELES AND THE ARTS:** One of Veles's most distinctive attributes — and one of the most unusual for an underworld deity — is his specific association with music, poetry, and the sacred arts. The velkhvy (the Slavic sacred specialists, the shamans) were understood as under Veles's specific protection. The bylina singers who preserved the epic tradition were under his patronage. The arts are underworld gifts — they come from the deep, hidden places of existence, not from the clear sky above.

MARZANNA

Goddess of Winter and Death — THE LIVING CEREMONY — Step-by-Step

Marzanna (Polish: Marzanna or ■mier■-Marzanna — 'Death-Marzanna'; Czech: Morana or Smrtka; Slovak: Morena; Ukrainian: Mara) is the Slavic goddess of winter, death, disease, and the end of the dark season — and the subject of one of the most remarkable surviving pre-Christian ceremonies in the world: the annual drowning of her effigy to drive away winter and welcome spring.

THE MARZANNA CEREMONY — STEP-BY-STEP (STILL PRACTICED TODAY)

THIS CEREMONY IS LIVING — it is practiced every year across Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Ukraine, and Belarus. The specific date varies by community and region but typically falls in mid-to-late March (the Sunday before Palm Sunday, or the first day of spring).

PREPARATION (DAYS BEFORE): The Marzanna effigy is constructed — traditionally a straw figure in a white dress (white as the color of winter and of death in Slavic tradition), decorated with ribbons, beads, and specific winter symbols. The effigy is made by the community collectively, particularly by women and girls. THE CEREMONY — THE DAY OF: STEP 1 — THE PROCESSION BEGINS: The community gathers carrying the Marzanna effigy through the village — a noisy, celebratory procession with singing, music, and specific ceremonial songs that address Marzanna directly. The songs typically command her to leave, to take winter with her, and to make room for spring. STEP 2 — THE TAUNTING SONGS: During the procession, specific songs taunt Marzanna — mocking her power, declaring her reign over, commanding her departure. The songs are simultaneously a ceremony and a declaration: winter is ending because we say it is ending. STEP 3 — THE BURNING (IN SOME TRADITIONS): Before reaching the water, some communities set the Marzanna effigy on fire — the burning driving out winter by fire as a complement to the drowning. STEP 4 — THE PROCESSION TO THE WATER: The procession moves to the nearest river, stream, or body of water — the specific water that will receive winter's body. STEP 5 — THE DROWNING: The Marzanna effigy is thrown into the water — sometimes pulled apart first (dismemberment of winter), sometimes thrown whole. The community watches it sink or float away. STEP 6 — THE PROHIBITION: After the drowning, no one may look back at the water. Looking back is understood as inviting winter to return. STEP 7 — THE SPRING SYMBOL: The community returns to the village carrying a decorated tree branch (the Gaik or Litonoška — the spring symbol) — the living green of spring carried home in triumph to replace the dead straw of winter. THIS CEREMONY IS NOT RECONSTRUCTION — it has been practiced continuously across Slavic countries, and contemporary celebrations draw thousands of participants.

KUPALA NIGHT

Ivan Kupala — The Midsummer Sacred Night — Step-by-Step

KUPALA NIGHT — COMPLETE STEP-BY-STEP

TIMING: The night of June 23-24 (the eve of the feast of Saint John the Baptist, hence 'Ivan Kupala' — Ivan = John). Pre-Christian timing was the summer solstice. Also called Midsummer Night. **SACRED SIGNIFICANCE:** Kupala Night is the most powerful night in the Slavic sacred calendar — the night when the boundary between the human world and the spirit world is thinnest, when sacred plants acquire their maximum power, when the fern flower (a legendary plant that blooms only on Kupala Night, granting its finder hidden treasure and magical power) may be found, and when specific sacred ceremonies of fire, water, and sacred herbs perform their maximum effect. **STEP 1 — THE SACRED FIRES:** Large bonfires are lit — the Kupala fire as the primary sacred element of the night. Communities gather around the fires. **STEP 2 — JUMPING THE FIRE:** Couples jump the bonfire together — a sacred act of purification, of love affirmation, and of divination (if the joined hands are not broken as they cross the fire, the love is true). **STEP 3 — THE FLOWER CROWNS:** Wreaths of sacred herbs and flowers are made — specific plants gathered specifically for this night (St. John's Wort, ferns, meadowsweet) have their maximum sacred power on Kupala Night. **STEP 4 — THE WATER DIVINATION:** Flower crowns are set on the water with a candle — the direction they float reveals sacred information about the year ahead. **STEP 5 — THE SEARCH FOR THE FERN FLOWER:** Young people go into the forest to search for the legendary fern flower — which blooms only once a year on Kupala Night. The search is simultaneously a sacred quest, a courtship ritual, and a test of courage. **STEP 6 — THE SACRED HERBS:** Specific herbs gathered on Kupala Night are dried and kept for the year as medicine and sacred protection — their power fixed by the night's specific sacred quality. **STEP 7 — THE DAWN:** The ceremony closes at dawn — the community greeting the sunrise together as the sacred night's completion.

BABA YAGA and THE FIREBIRD

The Forest Witch and Sacred Light

Baba Yaga is the most distinctive and most philosophically complex figure in Slavic sacred tradition — a supernatural being who lives in the deepest forest, in a house that stands on chicken legs, who simultaneously represents the most frightening possible encounter (she eats people) and the essential source of wisdom and sacred assistance for those who approach her correctly.

BABA YAGA — COMPLETE SACRED PORTRAIT

WHAT BABA YAGA IS: Baba Yaga is simultaneously a goddess of death and transformation, the guardian of the threshold between the living world and the underworld, a crone figure of supreme wisdom, and a test-giver whose nature determines whether the hero receives her help or her destruction. She is not evil — she is beyond good and evil, operating according to the specific sacred logic of the deep forest and the deep transformation that the hero needs.

HER HOUSE: Baba Yaga's house stands on chicken legs in the deep forest — it turns itself when approached, presenting its back to the visitor. The specific instruction for entering: 'House, house, turn your back to the forest and your face to me.' The house's rotation on approach is Baba Yaga's first test — only those who know the specific words can enter.

HER CHARACTER: Baba Yaga is an old woman with iron teeth and a bony leg (her name suggests 'old bone leg'). She flies through the sky in a mortar, steering with a pestle and sweeping her tracks with a broom. She simultaneously knows everything and will use that knowledge for or against the hero depending entirely on how the hero approaches her.

THE SACRED TEST: Every encounter with Baba Yaga is a specific test of sacred worth. The hero who arrives asking for help before bathing and eating (before respecting the protocols of her household) is refused or eaten. The hero who bathes, eats, and observes the specific protocols of guest-host relationship — who approaches with courtesy, with specific sacred words, and with the correct intentions — receives the specific wisdom, the specific sacred object, or the specific information that the quest requires.

BABA YAGA AS WISDOM TRADITION: Baba Yaga's ambiguity — simultaneously the most dangerous being in the forest and the essential source of sacred wisdom — reflects a genuine understanding of the sacred wisdom tradition. The deepest knowledge is not available without danger. The wisdom that transforms the hero cannot be safely delivered by a pleasant guide. Transformation requires encountering the figure who both threatens and enlightens.

THE FIREBIRD (ZHAR-PTITSA): The Firebird is a miraculous being whose feathers glow with the light of a thousand flames — appearing at night, leaving the landscape transformed, sought by heroes in the most famous Russian sacred tales. The Firebird is simultaneously a specific sacred being and the principle of divine light manifested in the natural world — the specific quality of sacred beauty that the hero is charged with capturing, protecting, or bringing back from the world's most dangerous places.

THE HOUSEHOLD SPIRITS

Domovoi, Dvorovoi, Kikimora — THE DOMOVOI CEREMONY

The Slavic household spirit tradition is one of the most developed and most practically oriented expressions of the broader European household spirit tradition — a specific sacred ecology of beings who govern specific domestic spaces and whose proper acknowledgment maintains the household's wellbeing.

THE HOUSEHOLD SPIRITS — COMPLETE

THE DOMOVOI (MASTER OF THE HOUSE): The primary Slavic household spirit — understood as the spirit of the house's founding ancestor, inhabiting the domestic space and governing its wellbeing. The domovoi lives behind the hearth or under the threshold. He is felt rather than seen — his presence manifests as specific sounds, specific sensations, specific impressions that experienced household members recognize. A pleased domovoi maintains the house's order; an offended domovoi causes specific disruptions.

THE DVOROVOI (SPIRIT OF THE YARD): The spirit who governs the yard and outbuildings — the domestic space outside the house itself. The dvorovoi is generally considered less benevolent than the domovoi and requires specific acknowledgment to maintain peaceful coexistence.

THE KIKIMORA: A female spirit associated with spinning and weaving — sometimes benevolent (assisting with household tasks, a good sign) and sometimes malevolent (tangling thread, disrupting sleep, causing disorder). The kikimora's character depends on how she entered the household — a kikimora established through proper ceremony is a helper; one who arrived through improper means or as a result of a curse is a troublemaker.

THE DOMOVOI CEREMONY — STEP-BY-STEP

MOVING INTO A NEW HOME: STEP 1 — THE CAT FIRST: A cat is the first living being to enter a new home — the cat serves as a preliminary spirit encounter, walking through the space and demonstrating by its behavior (where it rests, where it avoids) the specific spiritual geography of the new space. STEP 2 — THE BREAD AND SALT: Bread and salt — the sacred foods of Slavic hospitality — are brought into the new home as the first household goods. These offerings acknowledge both the domovoi and the sacred traditions of hospitality. STEP 3 — THE INVITATION TO THE OLD DOMOVOI: In the tradition of moving from an old house, the departing family formally invites the old house's domovoi to accompany them to the new home — speaking specific words at the old hearth, taking a coal from the old fire to kindle the new one. STEP 4 — THE FIRST FIRE: The first fire in the new home is kindled with specific prayers — welcoming the domovoi to his new residence, acknowledging his authority over this space. ONGOING MAINTENANCE: STEP 5 — NIGHTLY ACKNOWLEDGMENT: Specific foods (bread, salt, sometimes a small bowl of porridge) left near the hearth as regular acknowledgment of the domovoi's presence and care. STEP 6 — THE PROHIBITIONS: Specific actions that offend the domovoi are avoided — whistling indoors (considered an invitation to malevolent spirits), leaving the broom upright overnight, specific discourtesies at the threshold. STEP 7 — HEARING THE DOMOVOI: When the domovoi's presence is felt — specific sounds, specific sensations — the household member responds with specific acknowledgment rather than fear.

The Haligricity Lens

The Eternal Conflict as Sacred Teaching

The Slavic tradition's most original philosophical contribution to the library is the Perun-Veles eternal conflict — the understanding that the sacred order is not maintained through the permanent victory of one principle over another but through the continuous dynamic tension between sky and underworld, manifest and hidden, order and depth.

Every storm is the same battle. Perun descends with his lightning, Veles retreats with what he has taken, the rain comes when Veles releases the water, and the world is fed. Neither wins permanently because the world requires both. The domovoi lives behind your hearth right now. Baba Yaga is in the deep forest waiting to eat you or help you depending entirely on whether you know the right words and have the right intentions. Marzanna's effigy goes into the river every spring across Poland and Ukraine — the drowning of winter is not metaphor, it is a ceremony that has been performed continuously for more than a thousand years. The sacred world before Christianity is not past tense. It drowned the straw woman and came home with the green branch. Grand Rising.

*"Marzanna goes into the river.
Winter goes with her.
We do not look back.
We come home with the green branch.
This is how spring has always been made."*

— On the Marzanna drowning ceremony, still practiced across Slavic countries

Marzanna is drowned every spring across Poland, Czech Republic, Slovakia, Ukraine, and Belarus. Kupala Night bonfires are jumped every midsummer. The domovoi still lives behind the hearth in the understanding of households that remember. Baba Yaga still waits in the deep forest. The Perun-Veles conflict still plays out in every thunderstorm over Eastern Europe. The sacred world before Christianity was too alive, too deeply embedded in the seasonal rhythms and the household practices, to be entirely erased. It persists. Grand Rising.

Personal Reading Series | Haligricity | I.Q. Productionz | June 2026